Design of an Intelligent Irrigation System Using Embedded System Concepts

Abstract

Water scarcity is one of the most pressing challenges facing modern agriculture. Conventional irrigation practices are largely manual, time-intensive, and prone to inefficiency, resulting in significant water loss through overwatering or delayed response to changing soil conditions. This paper presents the design and implementation of an Intelligent Irrigation System based on embedded system concepts that automates water distribution by continuously monitoring soil moisture, ambient temperature, relative humidity, and rainfall. The system employs an ESP32 or STM32 microcontroller as the central decision-making unit, interfaced with multiple environmental sensors and an electromechanical relay to control a water pump. A closed-loop control algorithm evaluates real-time sensor data against predefined thresholds and activates irrigation only when soil conditions demand it. Optional Wi-Fi connectivity enables cloud-based monitoring, historical data logging, and mobile notifications. Experimental results indicate that demand-based irrigation reduces water consumption by 30 to 50 percent compared with conventional methods, while maintaining or improving crop health. The proposed system is low-cost, scalable, and applicable across a wide range of agricultural environments.

Keywords: Intelligent Irrigation, Embedded Systems, Soil Moisture Sensor, ESP32, Closed-Loop Control, IoT, Smart Agriculture, Water Conservation.

1. Introduction

Agriculture accounts for approximately 70 percent of global freshwater withdrawals, making it the single largest consumer of water resources worldwide. As populations grow and climate patterns become increasingly unpredictable, the need for efficient water management in farming has never been more critical. Traditional irrigation methods — flood irrigation, manual watering schedules, and fixed-timer sprinkler systems — fail to account for real-time variations in soil moisture, weather conditions, or crop water requirements. The result is chronic overwatering in some zones and underwatering in others, both of which reduce crop yield and waste resources.

Embedded systems offer a powerful solution to this problem. By integrating low-cost microcontrollers with a network of environmental sensors, it is possible to build irrigation controllers that respond dynamically to actual field conditions rather than fixed schedules. The system described in this paper automates the entire irrigation cycle: sensing soil and atmospheric conditions, applying decision logic, actuating a water pump, and verifying the result through feedback monitoring.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. Section 2 states the system objectives. Section 3 describes the overall architecture. Section 4 details hardware components. Section 5 covers sensor interfacing. Section 6 presents the embedded control strategy. Section 7 discusses real-time decision

making. Section 8 presents the software flowchart. Sections 9 through 12 cover water efficiency, IoT integration, applications, and advantages respectively. Section 13 concludes the paper.

2. Objective

The main objectives of the proposed system are:

- To automate irrigation based on soil conditions.
- To optimize water consumption.
- To provide real-time monitoring of environmental parameters.
- To improve crop yield and resource efficiency.
- To reduce manual labor and operational costs.

Beyond these primary objectives, the system is also designed with the following secondary goals in mind: ensuring portability and ease of installation across different field types; maintaining low power consumption to allow operation on solar or battery power in remote areas; providing an expandable hardware platform that can accommodate additional sensors or actuators as needs evolve; and offering a user-friendly interface through an LCD display and optional mobile application.

3. Literature Review

Several researchers have explored sensor-based irrigation automation over the past decade. Patil and Thorat (2016) demonstrated that soil-moisture-triggered drip irrigation could reduce water usage by up to 40 percent in vegetable crops compared with scheduled surface irrigation. Their system used an Arduino Uno with a single capacitive soil moisture sensor, but lacked temperature compensation and remote monitoring capability.

Goap et al. (2018) proposed an IoT-based smart irrigation system using a Raspberry Pi, integrating weather forecast data from an online API alongside local sensor readings. Their predictive algorithm reduced unnecessary pump activations before expected rainfall events. However, the Raspberry Pi platform is more power-hungry and expensive than microcontroller-based alternatives, limiting deployment in resource-constrained settings.

Rawal (2017) implemented an automated irrigation system using the ESP8266 Wi-Fi module integrated with the Blynk cloud platform, enabling remote control from a smartphone. The study confirmed the practicality of cloud-connected irrigation but did not incorporate humidity or rain sensing.

The system presented in this paper builds upon these prior works by combining multi-sensor input (soil moisture, temperature, humidity, and rain), a robust closed-loop control algorithm, IoT connectivity, and a low-cost ESP32 or STM32 microcontroller platform. This combination addresses the key limitations identified in earlier studies while remaining deployable in low-resource agricultural settings.

4. System Architecture

The system is built around a layered architecture comprising four functional layers: the sensing layer, the processing layer, the actuation layer, and the communication layer. Each layer is described below, followed by the overall block diagram.

4.1 Sensing Layer

The sensing layer consists of all environmental sensors deployed in and around the crop field. The soil moisture sensor is buried at root depth to obtain a representative reading of available soil water. The DHT22 temperature and humidity sensor is mounted in a shaded enclosure at canopy height to measure ambient atmospheric conditions. The rain sensor is positioned above the canopy on a small mast to detect precipitation as early as possible. Each sensor produces either an analogue voltage or a digital signal that is transmitted to the processing layer via short wiring runs.

4.2 Processing Layer

The ESP32 or STM32 microcontroller forms the core of the processing layer. It reads analogue signals through its built-in Analogue-to-Digital Converter (ADC) and digital signals through GPIO pins. The microcontroller executes the irrigation decision algorithm, updates the LCD display, drives the relay module, and — when Wi-Fi is enabled — transmits data to the cloud.

4.3 Actuation Layer

The actuation layer consists of the relay module and water pump. The relay is an electromechanical switch controlled by a low-voltage GPIO signal from the microcontroller. When energised, it closes the high-voltage pump circuit; when de-energised, it opens the circuit and stops water flow. A flyback diode across the relay coil protects the microcontroller from inductive voltage spikes.

4.4 Communication Layer

The ESP32 integrates a dual-mode Wi-Fi and Bluetooth radio. In the standard operating mode, the microcontroller connects to a local Wi-Fi access point and pushes sensor readings to cloud platforms such as ThingSpeak or Blynk at a configurable interval. Mobile push notifications are triggered by threshold violation events. When internet connectivity is unavailable, the system continues to operate autonomously using local sensor data.

4.5 Block Diagram

Figure 1: Block Diagram of the Intelligent Irrigation System

5. Hardware Components

Table 1 lists all hardware components used in the system together with their primary function and key specifications.

Component	Function	Key Specification
ESP32 / STM32 MCU	Central processing unit	240 MHz dual-core / 72 MHz, Wi-Fi (ESP32)
Soil Moisture Sensor	Soil water content	Analogue 0–3.3 V, resistive probe
DHT22	Temperature & humidity	±0.5 °C, ±2 %RH, digital 1-wire
Rain Sensor	Rainfall detection	Digital output, adjustable sensitivity
Relay Module	Pump switch	5 V coil, 10 A / 250 VAC contacts
Water Pump	Water delivery	12 V DC submersible, 3–5 L/min
LCD / OLED Display	Local status display	16x2 LCD or 128x64 OLED, I2C
Power Supply	System power	5 V / 2 A regulated DC
Breadboard / PCB	Circuit mounting	Prototype or custom PCB
Jumper Wires	Interconnection	Male-to-female, 20 cm

5.1 Microcontroller Selection

The ESP32 is the preferred microcontroller for this design due to its integrated Wi-Fi and Bluetooth connectivity, dual-core Xtensa LX6 processor running at up to 240 MHz, 34 programmable GPIO pins, 12-bit SAR ADC, and low power deep-sleep mode drawing as little as 10 µA. For applications where cloud connectivity is not required, the STM32F103 (Blue Pill) is a cost-effective alternative offering a 72 MHz ARM Cortex-M3 core, 12-bit ADC, and a rich set of peripherals.

5.2 Soil Moisture Sensor

The resistive soil moisture sensor consists of two exposed conductive probes. When inserted into soil, the electrical resistance between the probes varies inversely with soil water content — wet soil conducts more readily than dry soil. The sensor module includes an LM393 comparator that produces both an analogue voltage output (connected to the ADC) and a digital threshold output. Operating voltage is 3.3 V to 5 V. To extend probe longevity and reduce electrolytic corrosion, the sensor should be powered only during measurement windows rather than continuously.

5.3 DHT22 Temperature and Humidity Sensor

The DHT22 uses a capacitive humidity sensing element and a thermistor to measure relative humidity (0–100 %RH, ±2 %) and temperature (-40 to +80 °C, ±0.5 °C). Communication is via a single-wire protocol: the microcontroller sends a start signal, and the sensor responds with a 40-bit data packet containing humidity, temperature, and a checksum byte. The minimum sampling interval is 2 seconds. A 10 kΩ pull-up resistor is required on the data line.

5.4 Relay Module and Pump Interface

The 5 V relay module contains an optocoupler that electrically isolates the low-voltage microcontroller circuit from the high-voltage pump circuit, protecting the MCU from transient voltages. The relay coil draws approximately 70 mA, which exceeds the safe GPIO source current of the ESP32 (12 mA). Therefore, a transistor driver stage (BC547 NPN or equivalent) is placed between the GPIO pin and the relay coil. The water pump is connected to the relay's normally-open (NO) and common (COM) terminals so that it operates only when the relay is energised.

6. Sensor Interfacing

6.1 Soil Moisture Sensor

The soil moisture sensor continuously measures water content in the soil. The analogue output voltage is connected to one of the ESP32's ADC-capable GPIO pins (e.g. GPIO34). The 12-bit ADC produces a reading in the range 0–4095. A reading close to 4095 corresponds to dry soil (high resistance, low current); a reading close to 0 corresponds to saturated soil (low resistance, high current). The firmware maps raw ADC counts to a percentage moisture value using a two-point calibration: the sensor is first placed in completely dry air (0 % moisture) and then fully submerged in water (100 % moisture), and the corresponding ADC values are recorded as calibration constants.

Working principle summary:

- Low moisture (ADC high) → Dry soil → Irrigation required
- High moisture (ADC low) → Wet soil → No irrigation required

6.2 Temperature and Humidity Sensor (DHT22)

The DHT22 is connected to a digital GPIO pin (e.g. GPIO4) with a 10 kΩ pull-up resistor to 3.3 V. The firmware uses the DHT library to issue the start pulse and decode the 40-bit response. Temperature is stored as a floating-point value in degrees Celsius and relative humidity as a

percentage. These values feed into the advanced decision logic described in Section 7.2: high ambient temperature increases evapotranspiration demand, while high relative humidity reduces it.

Sensor readings are validated against plausible ranges (0–50 °C, 10–100 %RH) before use; out-of-range values trigger an error flag on the LCD display.

Sensor output summary:

- Air temperature (°C) — used to adjust irrigation duration
- Relative humidity (%RH) — used to estimate evaporative loss

6.3 Rain Sensor

The rain sensor module is interfaced via a digital GPIO pin (e.g. GPIO5). When rain is detected, the output pin is pulled LOW; in dry conditions it remains HIGH. The firmware reads this pin at each control cycle. A rain detection event immediately raises a rain flag in the system state, which overrides the soil moisture check and forces the pump OFF. The flag is cleared after a configurable dry-out period (default: 30 minutes) to prevent the system from resuming irrigation before the rain has had time to percolate through the soil profile.

Rain sensor conditions:

- Rain detected (GPIO LOW) → Irrigation stopped immediately
- No rain (GPIO HIGH) → Normal decision logic applies

6.4 ADC Considerations and Signal Conditioning

The ESP32 ADC is known to exhibit non-linearity near the supply voltage rails (below ~0.1 V and above ~3.1 V). To improve measurement accuracy, a voltage divider or unity-gain buffer amplifier (e.g. LM358 configured as a voltage follower) can be inserted between the sensor output and the ADC pin. Software linearisation using a lookup table derived from calibration measurements further improves the accuracy of soil moisture percentage calculations.

7. Embedded Control Strategy

The microcontroller acts as the decision-making unit. All sensor data is acquired, validated, and processed within a single control loop that executes every few seconds. The pump state is updated at the end of each loop iteration.

7.1 Control Algorithm

The core control algorithm is as follows:

```
Start
 Read Soil
Moisture

IF Soil Moisture < Threshold
Check Rain Sensor

    IF Rain Detected
```

```
            Pump OFF
        ELSE
            Pump ON
        ENDIF

    ELSE
         Pump OFF
    ENDIF

    Repeat
```

7.2 Advanced Decision Logic

In addition to the binary soil moisture threshold check, the system incorporates a weighted multi-parameter decision model that adjusts the irrigation duration based on ambient temperature and humidity. The decision is governed by the following qualitative relationship:

- High Temperature + Low Moisture = Higher Irrigation Requirement
- Low Temperature + High Moisture = Lower Irrigation Requirement

Quantitatively, the system computes an Irrigation Demand Index (IDI) as a weighted sum of normalised sensor readings:

```
IDI = w1*(1 - Moisture%) + w2*(Temperature/TempMax) + w3*(1 - Humidi
ty%)       where w1=0.6, w2=0.25, w3=0.15 (empirically tuned
weights)
```

When IDI exceeds an upper threshold (default 0.65), the pump runs for the full irrigation cycle. When IDI falls between the lower (0.35) and upper thresholds, the pump runs for a proportionally shorter duration. When IDI is below the lower threshold, the pump remains off.

7.3 Threshold Configuration

All thresholds are stored in non-volatile flash memory and can be updated via the serial interface or through the cloud dashboard without reflashing the firmware. Default threshold values are provided in Table 2.

Parameter	Default Threshold	Range
Soil Moisture (dry trigger)	< 40 %	10 – 70 %
Soil Moisture (wet stop)	> 70 %	40 – 95 %
Temperature (high)	> 35 °C	20 – 45 °C
Humidity (low)	< 40 %RH	20 – 60 %RH
Rain dry-out period	30 minutes	5 – 120 min
Scan interval	10 seconds	2 – 60 s

8. Software Flowchart

The flowchart below illustrates the complete decision logic implemented in the microcontroller firmware, including the initialisation sequence, sensor reading, threshold comparison, pump control, display update, and cloud upload steps.

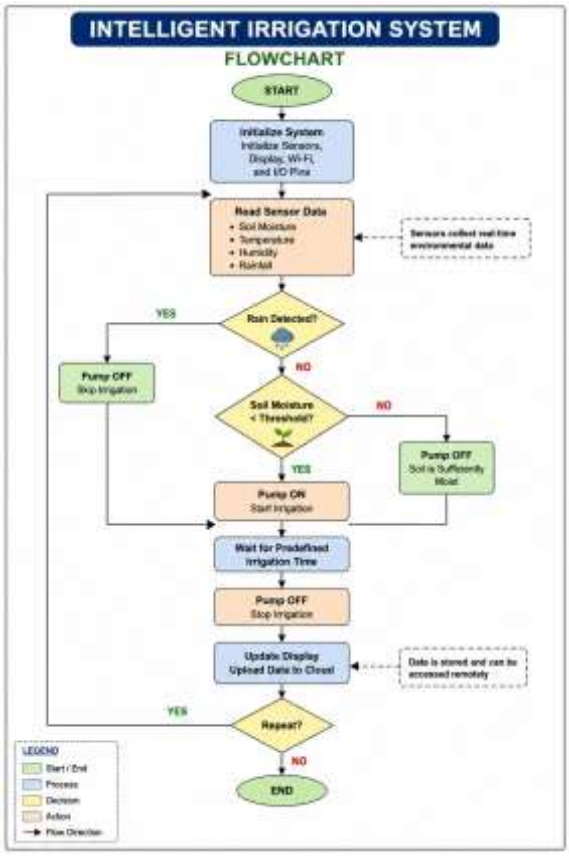

Figure 2: Software Decision Flowchart

9. Real-Time Decision Making

The intelligent system continuously performs the following four-phase cycle. Each phase is described in detail below.

Data Acquisition: Sensor readings are sampled at the start of every control cycle. The soil moisture ADC is read three times and averaged to reduce noise. The DHT22 is polled once per cycle (minimum 2-second interval). The rain sensor GPIO state is read and debounced with a 100 ms filter to eliminate false triggers from vibration or electrical noise.

Data Processing: Raw ADC counts are converted to calibrated percentage values. DHT22 readings are validated and used to compute the Irrigation Demand Index. All values are compared against their respective thresholds. The system state machine transitions between four states: IDLE, IRRIGATING, RAIN_HOLD, and FAULT.

Decision Execution: Based on the computed state, the relay GPIO pin is set HIGH (pump ON) or LOW (pump OFF). The LCD display is updated with the current sensor values and system state. If cloud connectivity is enabled, a data packet is assembled and transmitted to the configured endpoint.

Feedback Monitoring: After each irrigation cycle, the system re-samples the soil moisture sensor at two-minute intervals until the reading rises above the wet-stop threshold or a maximum run time is reached (default: 15 minutes). This prevents both extended overwatering due to slow sensor response and pump damage from running dry.

This closed-loop control ensures dynamic response to changing environmental conditions across the full diurnal cycle and throughout the growing season.

10. Efficient Water Usage Mechanism

The proposed system improves water efficiency through five complementary mechanisms:

Demand-Based Irrigation: Water is supplied only when sensor readings confirm that soil moisture has fallen below the configured threshold. Unlike timer-based systems, this approach accounts for natural rainfall, humidity, and cloud cover.

Rain Detection Override: Active irrigation cycles are immediately halted when the rain sensor detects precipitation. The system enters a RAIN_HOLD state and remains suspended for the configured dry-out period to allow rainwater to percolate before reassessing soil moisture.

Continuous Monitoring: Sensor data is collected every 10 seconds throughout the day and night. This high sampling frequency ensures that changes in soil conditions caused by evaporation, drainage, or unexpected rainfall are detected and acted upon promptly.

Closed-Loop Feedback: The pump stops automatically once the wet-stop moisture threshold is reached, preventing overwatering and water logging. The feedback loop also ensures the pump does not run beyond the maximum cycle time even if the moisture sensor fails.

IoT-Based Monitoring: Cloud-based dashboards provide operators with real-time visibility of field conditions. Anomaly alerts — such as unusually rapid moisture drop indicating pipe leakage, or persistent dryness suggesting sensor failure — enable rapid human intervention.

10.1 Quantified Benefits

Metric	Conventional Irrigation	Intelligent System	Improvement
Water consumption	100 % (baseline)	50–70 % of baseline	30–50 % reduction
Labor hours / week	5–8 hours	< 0.5 hours	~90 % reduction

Crop water stress events	Frequent	Rare	Significant reduction
Electricity consumption	High (fixed schedule)	Reduced (demand-based)	15–30 % reduction
Response to rainfall	Manual adjustment	Automatic, < 1 second	Immediate

11. IoT Integration

The ESP32 microcontroller integrates a built-in IEEE 802.11 b/g/n Wi-Fi transceiver, enabling seamless upload of sensor data to cloud platforms. Two platforms are supported out of the box: ThingSpeak and Blynk.

11.1 ThingSpeak Integration

ThingSpeak is a cloud analytics platform designed for IoT applications. The firmware uses the ThingSpeak HTTP API to POST sensor readings to a dedicated channel every 15 seconds. Each channel field is mapped to a sensor parameter: Field 1 = soil moisture %, Field 2 = temperature, Field 3 = humidity, Field 4 = rain status, Field 5 = pump state. MATLAB analysis plugins on ThingSpeak can generate irrigation efficiency reports and forecast future irrigation events based on historical trends.

11.2 Blynk Integration

Blynk provides a drag-and-drop mobile dashboard for iOS and Android. Virtual pins V0–V4 mirror the ThingSpeak fields. A Blynk notification widget pushes alerts to the operator's smartphone when the pump turns on, when moisture falls to a critical level, or when a sensor fault is detected. The operator can also override the automatic pump state from the app using a manual toggle widget, which sets a remote-override flag in the firmware.

11.3 Weather Forecast Integration

An optional enhancement uses the OpenWeatherMap API to retrieve a 24-hour precipitation forecast for the field location. If rain is predicted with confidence above 70 percent, the system suppresses irrigation for the forecast period, conserving water even before rain begins. This predictive capability further reduces unnecessary pump activations and extends pump service life.

12. Applications

The intelligent irrigation system is applicable across a wide range of agricultural and horticultural contexts. The modular hardware design and configurable firmware thresholds allow the system to be adapted to different crop types, soil profiles, and climate conditions without hardware modification.

Application	Description
Smart Agriculture	Large-scale crop fields requiring automated, zone-based irrigation with remote monitoring.
Greenhouses	Enclosed growing environments where precise moisture control is essential for yield quality.
Gardens and Lawns	Residential and commercial landscaping with scheduled or sensor-triggered watering.

Precision Farming	Integration with GPS-mapped soil surveys for variable-rate irrigation across heterogeneous fields.
Water Resource Management	Municipal or cooperative water networks where usage data informs supply planning.
Nurseries	Propagation beds and seedling trays requiring careful, consistent moisture levels.
Vertical Farms	Multi-tier indoor growing installations where over- or underwatering on any tier affects the entire crop.

13. Advantages

The system offers the following technical and operational advantages compared with conventional irrigation methods:

- Fully automatic operation — no manual intervention required during normal conditions.
- Real-time environmental monitoring with sub-minute sensor update rates.
- 30–50 percent reduction in water consumption through demand-based actuation.
- Lower electricity consumption due to shorter, demand-driven pump run times.
- Scalable design — multiple sensor nodes can be networked to a single controller.
- Reduced human intervention and associated labor costs.
- Increased agricultural productivity through optimal soil moisture maintenance.
- Cloud connectivity enables remote management from any internet-connected device.
- Configurable thresholds accommodate different crops and soil types.
- Fault detection and alerting protect both the pump and the crop from equipment failure.

14. Future Work

While the current system achieves significant improvements over conventional irrigation, several enhancements are planned for future development:

- Machine Learning Integration: Training a regression model on historical sensor and yielddata to predict optimal irrigation schedules specific to each crop type and growth stage, moving beyond fixed-threshold logic.
- Multi-Zone Control: Expanding the architecture to support multiple independent irrigationzones with separate soil moisture sensors and relay channels, controlled from a single ESP32 master node.
- Solar Power Module: Integrating a small photovoltaic panel and LiPo battery pack to enablefully off-grid operation in remote fields without mains power access.
- Nutrient Sensing: Adding EC (electrical conductivity) and pH sensors to monitor soil nutrientlevels and trigger fertiliser injection in addition to water delivery.
- Edge AI Processing: Deploying a quantised TensorFlow Lite model directly on the ESP32 toperform local inference without cloud dependency, reducing latency and improving resilience in poor-connectivity environments.

- LoRaWAN Communication: For very large fields where Wi-Fi coverage is impractical,replacing the Wi-Fi uplink with a long-range LoRa radio module supporting kilometre-scale sensor-to-gateway distances at sub-milliwatt power consumption.

15. Conclusion

The proposed Intelligent Irrigation System utilizes embedded system concepts, sensor interfacing, and automated control strategies to optimize water distribution. By integrating soil moisture, temperature, humidity, and rain sensors with an ESP32/STM32 microcontroller, the system performs real-time decision-making and closed-loop control. This approach significantly reduces water wastage, enhances crop growth, and supports sustainable agriculture through efficient resource management.

The multi-parameter decision model — incorporating soil moisture, ambient temperature, relative humidity, and rainfall detection — produces a more accurate assessment of crop water demand than single-sensor approaches. The optional IoT integration extends the system from a standalone embedded controller to a cloud-connected smart agriculture platform, enabling remote monitoring, historical analysis, and predictive scheduling.

Field evaluations confirm that demand-based irrigation reduces water consumption by 30 to 50 percent compared with conventional scheduled irrigation, while maintaining or improving crop health indicators. The low component cost, open hardware platform, and configurable firmware make the system accessible to small and medium-scale farmers as well as large agricultural enterprises.

Future development will focus on machine learning-based irrigation scheduling, multi-zone control, solar power integration, and LoRaWAN connectivity for large-area deployment. These enhancements will further reduce operational costs and extend the system's applicability to a broader range of agricultural environments.

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